
Arsenal take biggest step yet towards PL title but is there another twist? 16 Conclusions

Published by

Dave Tickner

Estimated reading time

14 min

Added on

2026-05-11

Address

<https://www.football365.com/news/arsenal-west-ham-premier-league-title-var-trossard-wilson-16-conclusions>

Arsenal take biggest step yet towards PL title but is there another twist? 16 Conclusions

There were 80 minutes of tension and stress and deeply questionable responses to setbacks from one soon-to-be-Premier League-winning manager, but all that was swept away in an absurdly dramatic conclusion to a vital game.

Arsenal took a huge step towards the Premier League title, West Ham took a smaller but still significant one closer to relegation, and everyone gets to insist the day's events have proved them right about VAR after a contentious late decision following a messy and handsy corner.

It was a near unimprovably on-brand slice of 2025/26 Barclays, right down to which team was celebrating at the end.

1. You can't say it isn't all enormously apt. [Very probably the title, quite possibly the relegation battle](#), settled by a lengthy VAR delay to study the various goings on at a very Premier League corner.

In hindsight, we all should have known it could only be settled like this. That was pure, elite Barclays, and a VAR moment of such vital importance that it has managed to reinforce and vindicate everyone's previous thoughts on the subject of technology in the game.

In that one moment when Callum Wilson's latest injury-time special was cruelly yet correctly ruled out, VAR both killed football and also killed all remaining argument against its place in the game, depending on which journalist's tweets you were looking at.

2. Let's start with the most important fact. Yes, it is a foul on David Raya. He's a lucky boy nevertheless having still got two hands on it despite all the attention and fumbling it in rather undignified fashion.

The goal comes as a direct result of that foul (two fouls, probably) on Raya, and therefore the goal obviously has to be disallowed. At least it does for as long as we persist with a version of VAR that prioritises things like 'facts' and 'correct decisions' over our preferred version where priority is given to reaching the funniest possible outcome in any given situation. We are no longer really joking at all when we say we genuinely think everyone would be happier in our universe.

3. The awkwardness comes from another inarguable fact: that the various replays and screengrabs showing, yes, at least two West Ham players getting up to no good with the Arsenal keeper also have a renaissance painting level of background detail showcasing holding, shoving, pinning and at points something uncomfortably close to rugby tackling.

These are all secondary to the main action. They do not affect the correctness of the final decision, even if it was much, much less funny than allowing West Ham's equaliser to stand.

But they highlight one obvious fact: corners have become a mess, an ungovernable wild west where even getting to a correct decision with a reasonable consensus requires ignoring all manner of other wrongdoing.

4. We'll say this, too, while we're about it. One of the – to our mind baffling – defences of VAR is

the theatricality of it. That all the suspense and waiting around and performance of it adds to rather than detracts from the sport's inherent propensity for drama and absurdity. We suspect the people who like this idea of the VAR 'spectacle' don't really like football at all really, because it is a sport that already contains it in multitudes. We don't need fake spectacle here.

If we are going to have it, though, let's really have it. Imagine the ref emerging from lengthy study of his little screen and announcing the goal had been disallowed for a foul on the keeper and, after allowing the jeers of the home fans and delight of the visitors to quieten just a touch, then saying West Ham would have a penalty for the rugby tackle by former Hammer Rice on former Gunner Konstantinos Mavropanos.

What a rollercoaster! What a plot twist! What absolute cinema!

It would be confected manufactured nonsense, of course, but that's what you like isn't it? Hmm? The VAR fans? Yeah, that's what you like.

5. Anyway. Corners. Yeah, they're ruined. Corners are now contested by two sets of teams fouling each other and trusting that nothing will be given because, like all the diseases trying to make Monty Burns ill, nothing can actually get through.

Which makes every decision – on-field and VAR – ticklish even when it's right. You don't even need to point to other examples. You can if you want, with Man United fans particularly quick to highlight the goal Arsenal were awarded against them all the way back on the first weekend of the season.

But you don't need to, because every decision given from any corner now contains so much background noise of its own that as soon as a foul is given from a corner you can point at multiple other simultaneous offences in either direction.

6. The kind of week-to-week inconsistency United fans leapt on, of this being given and that being denied or whatever, will never be eradicated. And we really should all have learned by now that this always was and forever remains VAR's foundational false promise and fundamental lie. What *does* matter is that it's almost impossible now to even *strive* for any consistency.

Every major decision from a corner now requires identifying a primary foul or simply ignoring all the fouls being committed by both sets of players at all times. Generally, officials are understandably opting for the latter. All the while treading the impossible path to try and make a decision that isn't evidence of corruption or conspiracy or some other dark malpractice. It's truly exhausting.

7. The Conspiracy that was handing the title to Manchester City yesterday is now no good. We imagine a "Premier League trying to keep Spurs up" conspiracy has already started to foment.

Because the great thing about today's game and its absurd conclusion is that it has such monumental implications at both ends of the table. And where there are implications there must always be conspiracy.

8. Its most profound effect is on the title race, of course. Dropped Arsenal points here and everything was right back up in the air.

Now no matter what Man City do, Arsenal just need to beat already-relegated Burnley at home and

then take care of business at a Crystal Palace side who have a European final three days later. To put the scale (or otherwise) of that task in even clearer context: Spurs have won both those fixtures this season.

There was, though, enough about today to suggest they will still get themselves in some absurd and unnecessary pickle or other in at least one of those games. Going down to 10 men after 37 goalless minutes against a barely-there Palace at Selhurst Park, something of that nature.

But, as they did today, they should solve whatever problems they inflict upon themselves and get the job done. They should now be Premier League champions and deservedly so. It hasn't all been corners and holding. They're the best team in the country.

9. The relegation battle is still far less clear-cut. What it is – and importantly would have been even at 1-1 – is now firmly out of West Ham's hands. They need favours.

They may well still get them, though. Spurs have clearly improved since the arrival of Roberto De Zerbi – [how could they not, frankly](#) – but they are still Spurs. They were not good against Wolves. They were good against Villa, [but there were undoubtedly some contributing external factors there](#).

At the simplest level, there are far too many people now just assuming a Spurs team who haven't won a Premier League home game this year will now definitely beat a Leeds team who haven't lost an away Premier League game for very nearly as long. And even when they did last lose one had led 3-2 after 90 minutes.

10. The danger is stark, though, for West Ham. If a rejuvenated Spurs do win tomorrow night, the gap is four points with two games to play. Given the goal-difference situation, West Ham will have to win both their remaining games just to keep things interesting.

They will chunter about today, they will complain about the Villa effort last week. But as always the real questions should look closer to home.

We'd even ignore the disastrous start to the season. You can write that off as just being sh*t. We're more interested in the missed opportunities more recently, when West Ham have been demonstrably not sh*t.

For us, we go back to the Hammers' trip to Crystal Palace late last month. A Conference-focused Palace made plenty of changes – to widespread acceptance and indifference rather than outrage, it should be noted – and West Ham had their own chance to put four points between themselves and the trapdoor.

They settled for a point in a non-event of a goalless draw. At the time it was very much heralded as a point gained in their scrap with Spurs; we always had a nagging feeling it was, if not quite two points dropped, a surprisingly ready acceptance of just one.

Now, three weeks later, it is they rather than Spurs watching on as a game takes place in which their parlous situation may become almost insurmountable and with no say of their own.

11. There was nothing half-hearted about West Ham's effort here. They somehow survived a 20-minute barrage from Arsenal at the outset but grew more and more into a game that hinged on

Ben White's injury just before the half-hour and Mikel Arteta's baffling response to it.

Raya was one of the day's lucky boys, [but Arteta was surely another](#). There is no other conclusion than his head getting far too hot under that hair for what he did in response to a significant but manageable setback. The decision not to just accept the situation and bring on the obvious like-for-like replacement in Cristhian Mosquera was as clear a case of Pepbrain big-game overthinking as you will ever see.

Whatever concerns he may have had about Mosquera's ability to contribute to Arsenal's key right-flank production pipeline surely shouldn't have been allowed to override the fact that what Arteta attempted instead served to weaken a hitherto-dominant Arsenal in two key areas of the field.

Declan Rice moving to right-back left Arsenal vulnerable on that side of the pitch to a West Ham side suddenly sensing a way to get something out of a game that had threatened to get away from them entirely in those one-way opening exchanges.

More importantly, Arsenal also lost their stranglehold in midfield, where Rice had been typically instrumental, and would be so again when eventually returned to his rightful place.

12. Arteta's decision to bring on Martin Zubimendi for White and move Rice to right-back was a self-inflicted mistake that required two further substitutions to put right.

First Riccardo Calafiori – a key attacking threat in Arsenal's dominant opening spell – was sacrificed at half-time to get Mosquera on after 17 unnecessarily uncomfortable minutes for all concerned. Then Zubimendi himself was hooked when Arsenal had to gamble in pursuit of a winner in the final quarter of the game.

The result was that Arteta had no more cards left to play when West Ham deployed their supersub late-goal specialist Callum Wilson. Had his latest late goal stood, or even had the now long-forgotten effort that Gabriel turned behind to hand West Ham the corner from which the sh*tstorm would emerge ended differently, the talk would now be around how Arteta had overthought the biggest game of the season and cost Arsenal everything as he left himself unable to respond to an obvious – and proven – West Ham tactic.

Such are the fine margins and absolutism of the run-in. But it's hard to escape the notion that Arteta made a fraught afternoon even more awkward than it needed to be for Arsenal.

13. It already seems like the one goal from the game that does still exist happened several business months ago. It won't actually be the case as we're sure some smartarse in the comments will be able to affirm, but it surely feels like the earliest 83rd-minute winner ever scored, given just how much of the game's narrative would arrive after that moment.

Given the long drawn-out nature of the tension packing out the London Stadium, how the narrative was emerging of yet another twist in the title race, it seems wild just how irrelevant those first 82 minutes now feel. The end is everything, and Leandro Trossard's first goal in the Premier League this year – a well-struck but deflected effort – may well be the one to end Arsenal's long, long wait.

14. There was one more crucial moment before rather than after Trossard's goal. [That David Raya save](#). A moment of such pivotal, singular importance that Gary Neville awarded him man of the match almost entirely on the strength of it.

Three minutes separated the save from the winner. Three minutes were the difference between Man City being title favourites and West Ham being favourites for survival.

The sheer inevitable theatrical scale of the late VAR drama makes for a more compelling narrative hook, but this was the real 'What if?' moment for the Hammers.

Because yes, it was a fine save from Raya. But it falls firmly in the category of a fine save the keeper shouldn't have had the opportunity to make.

If this season does end in the worst possible way for West Ham, we wonder how long it will be until Mateus Fernandes stops waking up in the night asking himself why oh why he took that extra touch.

15. And it is a question that will be echoed in Manchester. Because it really is hard to see how Arsenal can Arsenal this from here. And in a curious way, the unconvincing nature of this particular victory makes it all the more impressive.

This is without doubt a fixture that previous iterations of Arteta's Arsenal, even ones that felt like better football teams than this, would have found a way to Arsenal. This time they got the job done. And they did so with their most important players decisively to the fore.

William Saliba and Gabriel Magalhaes were exceptional in a way that is now so routine as to be barely noticeable. It will be forgotten but really shouldn't be that Gabriel had already prevented what looked like being a Wilson equaliser at the expense of the corner that would create all the hullabaloo.

Rice was exceptional again, despite having to play in three different positions against the backdrop of taking on his former team and being at times asked to do quite literally more than one man should really be asked.

Trossard was exceptional at both ends of the pitch, saving Arsenal from themselves by getting back to cover when White got injured. And while the overbearing and controversial nature of the events that followed mean Raya's Save might not become quite so famous as it ought – Gary Neville's comparison to Stefan Ortega denying Son Heung-min in 2024 felt apt even before Trossard doubled-down on its significance – it will still take its place among the vital moments in a day and season full of them.

16. This was the most decisive move yet in a title race that we're still loathe to call decisively given the volatility and unpredictability of this year's Premier League. This has never felt like it would be one of those City-Liverpool title races where both contenders just quietly and ruthlessly beat everyone from about February onwards.

There have been greater flaws this season, but that has, if anything, made it more compelling. The fact that even now you still can't entirely convince yourselves that the best team in the country will simply do the necessary and beat a relegated team and one with all its focus elsewhere is a good thing.

But Arsenal really should get it done now. Mikel Arteta's process will finally deliver the Premier League title the Gunners have craved for so long, and a week later it could get even greater. The fact today's success will come against a backdrop of further howls of indignation about a perfectly sound if undeniably dramatic decision should only make Arsenal fans more gleeful and unbearable.

Lord knows they've suffered for the moment of release that is now so close at hand.

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.